

Session 25: Blessing and Cursing Noah's Sons

Key Takeaways

- The genealogies of Genesis 10 are a form of symbolic ethnogeography. Later authors will use the established cast of characters and places to emphasize and subvert expected roles.
- Other people dwelling in the tents of Shem is a hopeful picture of God bringing blessing and reconciliation to all nations through the line of Shem.

The Blessing and Curse of Noah Upon His Sons

Genesis 9:25-27 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ And he said:

"Cursed be **Canaan**,
a **servant of servants**
he will be **to his brothers**."

²⁶ And he said:

"Blessed be Yahweh,
God of **Shem**,
and may Canaan be a **servant to him/them**."

²⁷ May God enlarge **Japheth**,

and may he dwell in the tents of **Shem**
and may **Canaan** be a **servant to him/them**."

Like Cain who also wronged a family member, Ham has aligned himself with the serpent through a replay of Adam and Eve's foolish rebellion. And so Ham's offspring Canaan, based on the maternal incest interpretation, is brought under the curse like Cain. Just as the snake became subject to humiliation in the dust because the seed of the woman will crush him (Gen. 3:15), so here the seed of Ham will be humiliated and become a slave to his brothers.

A glance forward to Genesis 10:15-18 shows us that the seed of Canaan will produce a large number of tribes who are hostile to the Israelites as they enter the land of Canaan.

#	People	Where Else They Appear
1	¹⁵ Canaan became the father of ...	Canaan/Canaanite: A geographical term to refer to all of the various tribes who were indigenous to the land of Canaan (borders described in Gen. 10:19). • Neutral to the Israelites: Gen. 12:6, 13:7, 50:11 • Hostile to the Israelites: Gen. 34:30; Exod. 15:15; Num. 13:29, 14:43-45, 21:1; Josh. 5:1, 7:9, 9:1; Judg. 1:1-17, 27-33; 3:3; 4:2, 23-24 • A religious/cultural "danger" to the Israelites: Gen. 24:3, 37; Exod. 23:23, 28; 33:2; 34:11; Josh. 14:1, 16:10
2	Sidon, his firstborn,	Sidon/Sidonians: The coastal region-city north of Canaan (modern Lebanon) • Friendly: 1 Kgs. 5:6, 17:9; Ezra 3:7 • Hostile: Josh. 11:8, 13:6; Judg. 3:3, 10:12 • Religious danger: Judg. 10:6; 1 Kgs. 11:1, 5; 16:31; 2 Kgs. 23:13 • Enslaved to Assyria and Babylon: Isa. 23:12; Jer. 25:22, 27:3, 47:4; Ezek. 27:8, 28:21-22
3	and Heth	Heth/Hittites: The region/tribe who inhabited Asia-Minor (modern Turkey) and migrated SE to inhabit Canaan • Friendly: Gen. 23, 49:29-30, 50:13; 1 Sam. 26:6; 2 Sam. 11; 1 Kgs. 10:29 • Hostile: Exod. 23:28, 34:11; Deut. 7:1, 20:17; Josh. 3:10, 9:1, 24:11 • Religious danger: Gen. 26:34, 27:46, 36:2; 1 Kgs. 11:1 • Enslaved to Israel: 1 Kgs. 9:20
4	¹⁶ and the Jebusite	Jebus/Jebusite: The tribe who inhabited ancient Jerusalem, called Jebus when it was a Canaanite city • Friendly: 2 Sam. 24:16, 18 • Hostile: Exod. 23:23, 34:11; Numb. 13:29; Deut. 7:1, 20:17; Josh. 9:1, 11:3, 15:63; Judg. 1:21; 2 Sam. 5:6-8 • Enslaved to Israel: 1 Kgs. 9:20
5	and the Amorite	A people who inhabited the upper Euphrates region; they spoke a Semitic language (Akkadian at Mari); many migrated into Canaan in the period of Abraham • Friendly/neutral: Gen. 14:13; 1 Sam. 7:14; 2 Sam. 21:2 • Hostile: Gen. 48:22; Exod. 23:23, 33:2, 34:11; Num. 13:29, 21:21-32 (Sihon), 32:39; Deut. 1:4, 27; 2:24; 3:8; 7:1; 20:17; Josh. 5:1, 9:1, 10:5-6, 24:11-12; Judg. 1:34-35 • Religious danger: Gen. 15:16, 21; Josh. 24:15, 18; Judg. 6:10; 1 Kgs. 21:26; 2 Kgs. 21:11 • Associated with the Nephilim giants Sihon and Og: Num. 21; Deut. 1:4, 27;
<i>The Families of Canaan.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

#	People	Where Else They Appear
		3:8; Amos 2:9-10 • Associated with Canaanite Jerusalem: Ezek. 16:3, 45
6	and the Girgashite	A tribe in the land of Canaan • Only ever mentioned in a list of Canaanite peoples: Gen. 15:21; Deut. 7:1; Josh. 3:10, 24:1
7	¹⁷ and the Hivite	A tribe in the land of Canaan • Friendly: Hivites = Gibeonites in Josh. 9:7, 11:19 • Hostile: Gen. 34:2 (Shechem and Hamor); Josh. 9:1, 11:3, 24:11; Judg. 3:3 • Religious danger: Gen. 36:2; Judg. 3:3 • Hostile: Exod. 23:23, 33:2, 34:11; Deut. 7:1, 20:17 • Enslaved to Israel: 1 Kgs. 9:20
8	and the Arkite	A Canaanite tribe; mentioned only in this genealogy and 1 Chron. 1:15
9	and the Sinite	A Canaanite tribe; mentioned only here and 1 Chron. 1:15
10	¹⁸ and the Arvadite	Arvad: A Northern Phoenecian island town (paired with Sidon in Ezek. 27:8, 11); a Canaanite tribe; mentioned only here and 1 Chron. 1:15
11	and the Zemarite	A city in the upper/Euphrates (likely mentioned in Ezek. 27:8); mentioned only here and 1 Chron. 1:16
12	and the Hamathite;	An Aramean city on the Orontes river north of Canaan • Friendly: 2 Sam. 8:9 • Hostile: 2 Kgs. 14:25-28 • Enslaved to Assyria and Babylon: 2 Kgs. 17:24, 30; Jer. 39:5, 49:23
and afterward the families of the Canaanite were scattered.		
<i>The Families of Canaan.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

In particular, the slave status of the Canaanites to their brothers anticipates the subjugation of these tribes by the Israelites (see [Deut. 7:1-2](#); [Josh. 11:12](#); [Judg. 1](#)).

However, just as Cain was not destined to be the seed of the woman or the snake by lineage, so also Ham's choice does not seal the fate of his descendants. Rather, it will be their own replay of Ham's illicit sexual behavior that gets them vomited out of the land (see [Lev. 18:24-28](#)).

"[T]he Canaanites are notorious throughout the Old Testament for their aberrant sexual practices, and [Leviticus 18:3](#) links both Egypt and Canaan as peoples whose habits are abominable: 'You shall not do as they do in the land of Egypt ... and ... as they do in the land of Canaan.' Ham's indiscretion towards his father may easily be seen as a type of the later behavior of the Egyptians and Canaanites. Noah's curse on Canaan thus represents God's sentence on the sins of the Canaanites, which their forefather Ham had exemplified."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15](#). Thomas Nelson. 201.

However, not all Hamites or Canaanites will repeat the sins of their ancestors; many will turn and give their allegiance to Yahweh, like Tamar, Rahab, and the Hivite-Gibeonites. And some apparently never gave up the worship of Yaweh, like Melchizedek in Genesis 14.

Is this a declarative curse or a request of the righteous before God?

"Is Noah praying and wishing that Canaan will be cursed, or is Canaan cursed because Noah has pronounced the anathema? Does ... [he] mean 'Cursed be Canaan' or 'Cursed is Canaan'? Now, there is no doubt that 'cursed,' when spoken by God, is declarative ... (Gen. 3:14, 17-19; 4:11). But does 'cursed' have one nuance in the divine mouth and another nuance in the human mouth? Here the optative thrust [= petition to God] seems preferable, for 'cursed,' a passive participle, is followed by four jussive requests ('may he be ...,' vv. 26-27; 'may he enlarge,' v. 27, and probably 'may he dwell,' v. 27). That Noah appeals to God in v. 27 also lifts the words of Noah out of the area of potent magic and into the realm of request."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1-17](#). Eerdmans. 324.

A Blessing for Yahweh of Shem

Interestingly, in contrast to Canaan's curse, Shem is not blessed himself. Rather, Yahweh is blessed and identified as the deity of Shem. Yahweh's covenant name is entrusted to Shem alone among the brothers; this is a subtle hint that it will be Shem's lineage that carries forward the seed of the woman (Gen. 3:15, 4:26).

"This is then the first intimation that the line of God's election blessing is going through Shem (cf. 4:26). The phrase 'the Lord, the God of Shem,' indeed anticipates many similar expressions in later texts, e.g., 'the Lord, the God of Abraham' [your fathers, Israel, etc.] ([24:27](#); [Exod 3:15](#), [32:27](#), [34:23](#))."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15](#). Thomas Nelson. 202.

Canaan's subjugation to Shem points forward to the narrative fulfillment in the period of Joshua (kind of). While the Israelites will make some descendants of Ham their slaves (the Canaanites), there will be many sons of Ham who in fact make slaves out of the sons of Shem and Ham: Egypt, Assyria, and most notably, Babylon.

A Future for Japheth ... and Shem ... and Canaan

Noah's words for Japheth (יָפֶֿתֿ) play on his name in Hebrew, Yephet (יֵפֶֿתֿ). The name comes from the root patah = "to make large." Noah anticipates that Japheth's territory will be expanded in the future.

The enlarging of Japheth invites the reader to study the list of Japheth's descendants in Genesis 10:2-5.

Genesis 10:2-5 NASB*

² The sons of Japheth:

Gomer and Magog and Madai and Javan and Tubal and Meshech and Tiras.

³ The sons of Gomer were Ashkenaz and Riphath and Togarmah.

⁴ The sons of Javan were Elishah and Tarshish, Kittim and Dodanim.

⁵ From these the islands of the nations were separated into their lands ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here we find tribes and nations that mostly make up ancient Anatolia (Roman Asia Minor, modern Turkey) and Greece. Noah anticipates that these tribes and nations will enlarge their territory and make their way into the territory of Shem.

“May he dwell in the tents of Shem” could be interpreted in two different ways.

“To displace, to disinherit”

There are some contexts where one group “dwelling in the tent” of another is the result of conflict and dispossession.

Psalms 78:55 NASB

[Yahweh] also drove out the nations before them, and apportioned them for an inheritance by measurement, and made the tribes of Israel **dwell in their tents**.

1 Chronicles 5:10 NASB*

In the days of Saul they made war with the Hagrites, who fell by their hand, so that they **dwelt in their tents** throughout all the land east of Gilead.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

On this reading, Noah’s words anticipate a future conflict between all of his children where Japheth dispossess Shem from his tent and makes Canaan his slave. Many texts throughout the Hebrew Bible activate this meaning. For example, this meaning is possible when the nations at war with Israel are from Japheth, or when a future conflict is anticipated between Israel and the nations.

In Genesis 14, five kings of the east (two from Ham and two from Japheth) come to enslave four rebellious kings of Canaan. In the conflict, Lot, a descendant of Shem, is taken captive. Abram, a son of Shem, and two Canaanite allies defeat the five kings and restore the captives. The Canaanite priest king Melchizedek also appears in this narrative, and he worships the creator God and blesses Abram.

The pagan prophet Balaam speaks about the future conflict between Noah’s sons (Num. 24:23-24). He speaks of a descendant of Japheth, the Kittim, who will come to oppress Asshur (from Ham and Shem) and Eber (from Shem).

This conflict is expanded and developed in Daniel 7:12 in the sequence of empires leading up to the final beast and horn that will displace the sons of Ham (Assyria and Babylon) and Shem (the Israelites) in terms of political power in the land promised to Abraham.

Noah's blessing on Japheth and its relation to the table of nations in Genesis 10 is also behind Ezekiel's fascinating oracle about Gog of Magog. Magog is a seed of Japheth and rules over his brothers Meshek and Tubal. He also brings the sons of Ham (Cush and Put) and non-Israelite sons of Shem (Persia/Elam) as mercenaries in his war with Israel after its restoration from exile. Ezekiel brings together the common Day of Yahweh motif where Yahweh destroys the seed of the serpent from among the nations (see [Isa. 13-14](#); [Joel 3-4](#); [Zech. 14](#)).

"To live together with"

Living in the same tent is an image of unity in some texts.

Psalm 15:1 NIV*

Yahweh, who may **dwelt in your sacred tent**? Who may live on your holy mountain?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The ideal state of God's covenant people is to "dwell in his tent," that is, to live with him in peace and harmony.

Job 11:14-15 NIV

¹⁴ If you put away the sin that is in your hand and allow no evil **to dwell in your tent**,

¹⁵ then, free of fault, you will lift up your face; you will stand firm and without fear.

Job's friends accuse him of living in unity with evil, which must be why he's suffering.

Psalm 120:5 NIV

Woe to me that I **dwelt** in Meshek, that I **live among the tents** of Kedar!

The poet laments that he has to live in the tents of Meshek (a descendant of Japheth) and Kedar (a son of Ishmael).

On this reading, Noah's words anticipate a day when all of his sons will live together in peace so that the "nations" (sons of Japheth) would be incorporated into the "tents of Shem," that is, experience Yahweh's covenant blessings.

- Genesis [12:1-3](#), [17:3-8](#), and [22:15-18](#) all point to this incorporation of the nations into the blessing of Abraham's family.
- [Isaiah 2:1-4](#) and [chapter 60](#) depict this gathering of the nations to live in the new Jerusalem and experience its abundance.
- [Zechariah 2:10-13](#) and [8:23](#) depict this same inclusion of the nations in the post-exile restoration of God's covenant people.

Zechariah 2:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ "Sing for joy and be glad, O daughter of Zion; for behold I am coming and I will dwell in your midst," declares the LORD. ¹¹ "Many nations will join themselves to the LORD in that day and will become my

people. Then I will dwell in your midst, and you will know that the LORD of hosts has sent me to you.”

Interestingly, Zechariah 14 brings together both potential meanings of Genesis 9:27. First there is a great conflict between the sons of Noah, resulting in a remnant among the nations that comes to the new Jerusalem to experience its Eden blessings.

Zechariah 14:1-3, 9-11, 16 NASB

¹ Behold, a day is coming for Yahweh when the spoil taken from you will be divided among you. ² For I will gather all the nations against Jerusalem to battle ... ³ Then Yahweh will go forth and fight against those nations, as when he fights on a day of battle. ...

⁹ And the LORD will be King over all the earth; in that day Yahweh will be the only one, and his name the only one. ¹⁰ All the land will be changed into a plain from Geba to Rimmon south of Jerusalem; but Jerusalem will rise and remain on its site from Benjamin's Gate as far as the place of the First Gate to the Corner Gate, and from the Tower of Hananel to the king's wine presses. ¹¹ People will live in it, and there will no longer be a curse, for Jerusalem will dwell in security. ...

¹⁶ Then it will come about that any who are remaining of all the nations that went against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, Yahweh of hosts, and to celebrate the Feast of Booths.

“If the dwelling of Japheth in the tents of Shem presupposes the conquest of the land of Shem by Japheth, it is a blessing not only to Japheth, but to Shem also, since, whilst Japheth enters into the spiritual inheritance of Shem, he brings to Shem all the good of this world (see Isa. 60). ‘The fulfilment,’ as Delitzsch says, ‘is plain enough, for we are all Japhethites dwelling in the tents of Shem; and the language of the New Testament is the language of Javan entered into the tents of Shem.’ ... Moreover it is true of the blessing and curse of Noah, as of all prophetic utterances, that they are fulfilled with regard to the nations and families in question as a whole, but do not predict, like an irresistible fate, the unalterable destiny of every individual; on the contrary, they leave room for freedom of personal decision, and no more cut off the individuals in the accursed race from the possibility of conversion, or close the way of salvation against the penitent, than they secure the individuals of the family blessed against the possibility of falling from a state of grace, and actually losing the blessing. Hence, whilst a Rahab and an Araunah were received into the fellowship of Jehovah, and the Canaanitish woman was relieved by the Lord because of her faith, the hardened Pharisees and scribes had woes pronounced upon them, and Israel was rejected because of its unbelief.”

Keil, C. F. and Delitzsch, F. (1996). [*Commentary on the Old Testament, Volume 1*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 101.

Noah's words invite us to ponder this portrait of the future of nations, using the patterns of Genesis 1-11 to anticipate just where the story is going. The table of nations, then, becomes a palette of future hope. The stories to follow, from Genesis 11 to the end of 2 Kings, all work out the programmatic poems in Genesis 3:14-15 and 9:25-27. There will be hostility between the seed of the woman and the seed of the snake.

- When the nations are at war, they are giving into the power of the snake that is luring them into jealous and angry violence (see “Gog of Magog” in [Ezek. 38-39](#)).
- When the nations become a “tent of Yahweh,” then humanity will see that they are brothers who can live together in peace ([Ps. 133](#); Isa. 2:1-4).

The Division of Noah's Sons: Macro Literary Design of Genesis 10:1-32

Sons Are Born

¹ And these are the generations of the sons of Noah, Shem, Ham, and Japheth, and there were born to them sons after the flood.

Sons of Japheth

Seven Sons" of Japheth

² Gomer, Magog, Madai, Yavan, Tubal, Meshek, Tiras

Seven "Grandsons" of Japheth

³⁻⁴ Gomer's sons: Ashkenaz, Riphath, Togarmah

Yavan's sons: Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, Dodanim

Conclusion

⁵ From these separated the islands of the nations in their lands, each into their language, into their families, by their nations.

Sons of Ham

Four Sons of Ham

⁶ Cush, Egypt, Put, Canaan

Seven Sons and Grandsons of Cush

⁷ Cush: Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Ra'amah, Sabtekah

Ra'amah: Sheba, Dedan

Narrative About Nimrod Building Babylon and Nineveh

⁸⁻⁹ Cush bore Nimrod (נמרד • *we will rebel*), he began (החל) to be a mighty warrior (גבור) in the land. He was a mighty warrior hunter (גבור ציד) before Yahweh, therefore it is said, "Like Nimrod, a mighty warrior hunter (גבור) before Yahweh."

¹⁰ The beginning of his kingdom (ממלכתו) was Babylon ... in the land of Shinar

¹¹⁻¹² From that land he (= Nimrod) went out to Assyria and Asshur built (בנה) Nineveh ... that is the great city (העיר הגדולה)

Seven Sons of Egypt + the Philistines

¹³⁻¹⁴ Ludim, 'Ananim, Lehabim, Naphtuhim, Pathrusim, Kasluhim (+ Philistines), Kaphtorim

Twelve Sons of Canaan

15-18 Sidon, Heth, Jebusite, Amorite, Girgashite, Hivite, 'Arkite, Sinite, Arvadite, Tsemarite, Hamathite, Canaanite

Narrative About the Borders of Canaan

¹⁹ From Sidon to Gerar to Gaza to Sodom and Gomorrah to Lasha

Conclusion

²⁰ These are the sons of Ham into their families, into their languages, in their lands, by their nations.

Sons of Shem

Introduction to Shem

²¹ Father of all the sons of Eber (= Hebrews)

Shem's Twelve Sons and Grandsons Until Peleg (=

22-25 Elam, Asshur, Arphachshad, Lud, Aram

Aram: Uz, Hul, Gether, Mash

Arphachshad: Shelah, Eber

Eber: Peleg and Joktan

Fourteen Descendants of Eber Through Joktan

26-30a Joktan: Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Yarach, Hadoram, Uzzal, Diqlah, 'Obal, Abimael, Sheba', Ophir, Havilah, Yobab

Narrative About the Dwelling Spots of Joktan's Offspring

³⁰ And their settlement extended from Mesha as you go toward Sephar, the hill country of the east.

Conclusion

³¹ "These are the sons of Shem into their families, into their languages, in their lands, into their nations.

Sons Divided

³² These are the families of the sons of Noah, in their generations, by their nations, and from these were separated the nations in the land after the flood.

Genesis 10:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Seventy Nations From Separating Brothers

Genesis 10:1-32 introduces all of the characters we will meet in the rest of the Hebrew Bible. In a way, this genealogy functions as a geo-ethnic map. Many of the names in this list are place names (Elam, Canaan, Assyria), or they are place names turned family names (Jebusites, Hittite).

If we were to draw this mental map, the following is one modern way of depicting the result.



Zerr, E.M. (1947). [Wixsite](#).

But geography is not the author's main concern in arranging and composing this genealogy. Noah's oracle in Genesis 9:25-27 has already anticipated the relations of these groups (see the notes for Session 23). But the total number of 70 and the arrangement of each set of descendants also communicates important theological claims.

"The peoples listed amount precisely to seventy, excluding Nimrod, who is an individual. There are fourteen Japhethites, thirty Hamites, and twenty-six Shemites. The figure seventy, even if not explicitly given, can hardly be fortuitous. The mere recognition in verse 5 of the existence of additional, unnamed 'maritime nations' lends added significance to the enumeration as being deliberately chosen. In the biblical world the number seventy is 'typological'; that is, it is used for rhetorical effect to evoke the idea of totality, of comprehensiveness on a large scale, as opposed to the use of seven on a smaller scale. Thus, according to [Genesis 46:27](#), the entire household of Jacob that went down to Egypt comprised seventy souls.

The representative body of the entire community of Israel in the wilderness consisted of seventy elders, as recorded in [Exodus 24:9](#) and [Numbers 11:24](#); and the prophet Ezekiel, in [8:11](#), uses the same figure at the end of the period of the monarchy. ... In light of this convention, one may safely assume that making the offspring of Noah's sons total seventy is a literary device to convey the notion of the totality of the human race. The same device is employed in rabbinic literature, where the phrases 'seventy peoples' or 'seventy languages' express humanity in its entirety. This device affords an insight into a major function of the Table, a document thus far unparalleled in the ancient world. This strangely perplexing miscellany of peoples, tribes, and places is no mere academic or scholastic exercise. It affirms, first of all, the common origin and absolute unity of humankind after the Flood. It also ... asserts that the varied ways that humans divide themselves are all secondary to the essential unity of the international community, which truly constitutes a family of man."

Adapted from Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [Genesis, The JPS Torah Commentary](#). Jewish Publication Society. 69.

"Thus the Bible indicates the perfection of humanity by its numerical harmony, and it is not Scripture's intention to cite the names of all the peoples seriatim. Those who conclude a priori that our chapter purports to present a complete ethnic list, and as a result of this premise discover a number of omissions, since in truth the list is incomplete, have failed to understand the chapter properly. It explicitly declares that its aim is not to mention all the peoples. It states, for example, in v. 5 with regard to the sons of Japheth: From these spread the coastland peoples in their lands, each with his own language, by their families, in their nations, that means to say, that there were many other nations in the world who traced their descent to Japheth, but there was no need to detail their names. Similar expressions are subsequently used with reference to the sons of Ham (v. 20), the sons of Shem (v. 31), and the sons of Noah as a whole (v. 32). The Torah was concerned only to complete the number of seventy names, and to incorporate therein the names of the principal nations that were near to Israel, or were in some way connected with the Israelites, or were in some manner known to them."

Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [From Noah to Abraham: A Commentary on the Book of Genesis, Part Two](#). Varda Books. 179-180.

This genealogy also continues the narrator's focus on the divinely chosen line that will be the "seed of the woman" (Gen. 3:15). The author presents multiple narratives where a generation of brothers divide, usually as a result of human folly or sin. Out of this divide God selects one promised lineage, and it's at this point that we are given diverging genealogies.

Narrative of Division	Gen. 4	Gen. 9	Gen. 16-17, 21	Gen. 25-33	Gen. 37-45
Genealogy of the Non-Chosen	Cain to Lemek Gen. 4:17-26	Japheth, Ham Gen. 10:1-32	Ishmael, sons of Keturah	Esau Gen. 36	The 10 brothers/tribes
Genealogy of the Chosen Line	Abel/Seth Gen. 5:1-32	Shem Gen. 11:10-32	Isaac Gen. 25:19	Jacob Gen. 37:1	Joseph & Judah

Diverging Genealogies. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

“After the genealogy of the sons of Japheth, the oldest of the sons of Noah, the Bible gives us the pedigree of the sons of Ham, the third son, in order to leave to the end—as the climax—Shem, who, although the middle one in order of birth, was the most important of them, since he was the primogenitor of the people of Israel. The Torah first completes the genealogy of Japheth and Ham so as to dispose of the subject and avoid the need to revert to it later; whereas the account of Shem’s offspring, who are central to the narrative, will continue in the subsequent chapters. In accordance with this principle, the descendants of Ishmael are listed first (25:12-18), so that the Bible may proceed afterwards to the history of Isaac’s children, who are the more important (25:19 ff.); similarly the roll of Esau’s sons (chapter 36) precedes that of Jacob (37:2 ff.).”

Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [From Noah to Abraham: A Commentary on the Book of Genesis, Part Two](#). Varda Books. 198.

The Sons of Japheth

Sons of Japheth

Seven Sons” of Japeth

² Gomer, Magog, Madai, Yavan, Tubal, Meshek, Tiras

Seven “Grandsons” of Japheth

³⁻⁴ Gomer’s sons: Ashkenaz, Riphath, Togarmah
Yavan’s sons: Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, Dodanim

Conclusion

⁵ From these separated the islands of the nations in their lands, each into their language, into their

families, by their nations.

Genesis 10:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The author has selected only two lists of Japheth's sons (Gomer and Yavan) that equal the number seven, thus matching the seven sons of Japheth as a whole. This shows the author's selectivity in reaching the number seven (שבע), which also means "to be full" or "complete" in Hebrew. The symbolic numbering communicates totality.

In the biblical imagination, these nations make up the distant regions ("the edges of the land") of the west. They represent an unknown and exotic realm of mainland and islands. In fact, sometimes these regions are simply called "the islands" (from Gen. 10:5; see [Ps. 72:10](#), [97:1](#); [Isa. 11:11](#), [24:15](#), [42:10](#), [51:5](#)).

When the biblical hope for the messianic Kingdom is portrayed, the "islands/coastlands" are often mentioned as a way to include the most distant regions of the land.

Psalm 72:8-11 NIV*

⁸ May [the seed of David] rule from sea to sea
and from the river to the ends of the earth.

⁹ May the desert tribes bow before him
and his enemies lick the dust.

¹⁰ May the kings of Tarshish and of the islands
bring tribute to him.

May the kings of Sheba and Seba
present him gifts.

¹¹ May all kings bow down to him
and all nations serve him.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 51:5 NASB*

My righteousness is near,
my salvation has gone forth,
and my arms will judge the peoples;
the islands will wait for me,
and for my arm they will wait expectantly.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 60:9 NIV

Surely the islands look to me; in the lead are the ships of Tarshish, bringing your children from afar, with their silver and gold, to the honor of the LORD your God, the Holy One of Israel, for he has endowed you with splendor.

Isaiah 66:18-19 NIV

¹⁸ And I ... am about to come and gather the people of all nations and languages, and they will come and see my glory. ¹⁹ I will set a sign among them, and I will send some of those who survive to the nations—to Tarshish, to the Libyans and Lydians ... to Tubal and Greece, and to the distant islands that have not heard of my fame or seen my glory. They will proclaim my glory among the nations.

Zephaniah 2:11 NASB*

The LORD will be terrifying to them, for he will destroy all the gods of the earth; and all the islands of the nations will bow down to him, everyone from his own place.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Conversely, these are also the nations that will rally around “Gog of Magog” in [Ezekiel 38-39](#).

The Sons of Ham

Sons of Ham

Four Sons of Ham

⁶ Cush, Egypt, Put, Canaan

Seven Sons and Grandsons of Cush

⁷ Cush: Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Ra’amah, Sabtekah
Ra’amah: Sheba, Dedan

Narrative About Nimrod Building Babylon and Nineveh

⁸⁻⁹ Cush bore Nimrod (נמרד • *we will rebel*), he began (החל) to be a mighty warrior (גבור) in the land. He was a mighty warrior hunter (גבור ציד) before Yahweh, therefore it is said, “Like Nimrod, a mighty warrior hunter (גבור) before Yahweh.”

¹⁰ The beginning of his kingdom (ממלכתו) was Babylon ... in the land of Shinar

¹¹⁻¹² From that land he (= Nimrod) went out to Assyria and Asshur built (בנה) Nineveh ... that is the great city (העיר הגדולה)

Seven Sons of Egypt + the Philistines

¹³⁻¹⁴ Ludim, ‘Anamim, Lehabim, Naphtuhim, Pathrusim, Kasluhim (+ Philistines), Kaphtorim

Twelve Sons of Canaan

¹⁵⁻¹⁸ Sidon, Heth, Jebusite, Amorite, Girgashite, Hivite, ‘Arkite, Sinite, Arvadite, Tseamarite, Hamathite, Canaanite

Narrative About the Borders of Canaan

¹⁹ From Sidon to Gerar to Gaza to Sodom and Gomorrah to Lasha

Conclusion

20 These are the sons of Ham into their families, into their languages, in their lands, by their nations.

Genesis 10:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The list of Ham's sons has the same design intentions as the list of Japheth's sons in 10:2-5.

- The author has chosen the firstborn son (Cush) for a list of five sons, but then chooses the fourth son of Cush to list his two sons, thus coming to total of seven.
- The seven sons of Egypt/Mizraim are listed, as these are all people associated with the Egyptian tribes of the southwest.
- The twelve sons of Canaan are surely a symbolic match to the twelve sons of Jacob, who will become the twelve tribes who will dispossess the twelve tribes of Canaan.

In this way, the narrator hints that just as Cain's own murderous act was magnified by his descendant Lemek, so also will Ham's shameful act be magnified by his descendent Canaan. And, of course, this is what Leviticus 18 and 20 make crystal clear.

The Narrative of Nimrod

Into the genealogical list of Canaan's son Cush, the author has inserted a narrative about the sixth son of Cush whose name was not listed in the genealogy. We are told all kinds of seemingly random bits of information about Nimrod, but the significance of every line is clear when we follow the hyperlinks to other texts in Genesis 1-11.

Genesis 10:8-12: Narrative Insert Into the Genealogy of Ham	Hyperlinks Within Genesis 1-11
10:8-9: Cush bore Nimrod [נמרד = "we will rebel"], he began (החל) to be a mighty warrior (גבור) in the land. He was a mighty warrior hunter (גבר-ציד) before Yahweh, therefore it is said, "Like Nimrod, a mighty warrior hunter (גבר-ציד) before Yahweh.	Gen 6:1 "It came about when humanity began (החל) to multiply ..." Gen 6:4 "The Nephilim were in the land in the those days, and also afterwards, when the sons of God went into the daughters of humanity, and they bore for them the mighty warriors (גבור) who were from ancient time, men of the name (שם)
10:10 The beginning of his kingdom (ממלכתו) was Babylon ... in the land of Shinar	11:2 "And when [all the land] set out from the east, they found a plain in the land of Shinar .
10:11 "from that land he [= Nimrod] went out to Assyria and Asshur built (בנה) Nineveh ... that is the	4:17-18: And Cain built (בנה + עיר) a city and called it the name [שם] of his son, Enoch ... Methushael
Nimrod and Hyperlinks to Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Genesis 10:8-12: Narrative Insert Into the Genealogy of Ham	Hyperlinks Within Genesis 1-11
great city (העיר הגדולה)	bore Lemek (למך) 11:4 “Let us build for ourselves a city (בנה + עיר) ... therefore they called its name (שם), Babylon. Jonah 1:2 Go to Nineveh, the great city (העיר הגדולה)
Nimrod and Hyperlinks to Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

In this narrative, a son of Ham named “we will rebel” is a violent warrior-hunter who builds both Babylon and Assyria’s capital city of Nineveh. Every part of this description is loaded with meaning and paints a larger-than-life portrait of Nimrod and the city-kingdoms that he represents.

The quest for a specific historical king of Mesopotamia has been unsuccessful and disputed, much like the search for the exact pharaohs referred to in Exodus 1-15. The biblical authors have deliberately blurred the portrait so that these imperial kings become narrative icons separate from their historical referent.

“The biblical Nimrod, then, is not a total counterpart of any one historical character. He is rather a composite Hebrew equivalent of the kings of the Sargon dynasty [in Mesopotamia of the late 2000’s B.C.E.]: the first mighty king to rule after the flood.”

Levin, Yigal (2002). “Nimrod the Mighty, King of Kish, King of Sumer and Akkad.” *Vetus Testamentum*, 52 (3). 350-366.

“Mighty Warrior-Hunter”

The word “mighty warrior” (Heb. *gibbor* / גבור) appears once before to describe the offspring of the sons of God and the human daughters. The early Jewish understanding of Nimrod as a giant (the Septuagint translated *gibbor* as *gigas* / γίγας) is also significant.

Let’s take a look at the important parallel alignment of Lemek and Nimrod in the literary design of Genesis 1-11.

Parallel	Genesis 1-6	Genesis 6-12
1st Generation	Adam and Eve	Noah
2nd Generation	Cain	Ham
3rd Generation	Lemek	Nimrod
Lemek and Nimrod. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

Parallel	Genesis 1-6	Genesis 6-12
Cosmic Rebellion	Genesis 6	Babylon
Divine Justice	the flood	the scattering
Seed of the Woman Remnant	Noah	Abraham
<i>Lemek and Nimrod. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

The Borders of Canaan

The biblical author includes a short description of the boundaries of the land of Canaan. This shows us the author's intends the list to anticipate Abraham and his descendants, who will be promised possession of this very land (Gen. 12:6, 15:7-21).

Genesis 10:18b-19 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And afterward, the families of the Canaanite were scattered. ¹⁹ And the border of the Canaanite was from Sidon as you go toward Gerar, as far as Gaza; as you go toward Sodom and Gomorrah and Admah and Zeboiim, as far as Lasha.

The Sons of Shem

Genesis 10:21 Instructor's Translation

Now, to Shem also children were born, he is the father of all the children of Eber/Hebrew, the brother of Japheth, the older one.

Introduction to Shem: Father of all the sons of Eber (= Hebrews)

Sons of Shem

Introduction to Shem

²¹ Father of all the sons of Eber (= Hebrews)

Shem's Twelve Sons and Grandsons Until Peleg (=

²²⁻²⁵ Elam, Asshur, Arphachshad, Lud, Aram

Aram: Uz, Hul, Gether, Mash

Arphachshad: Shelah, Eber

Eber: Peleg and Joktan

Fourteen Descendants of Eber Through Joktan

26-30a Joktan: Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Yarach, Hadoram, Uzzal, Diqlah, ‘Obal, Abimael, Sheba’, Ophir, Havilah, Yobab

Narrative About the Dwelling Spots of Joktan’s Offspring

30 And their settlement extended from Mesha as you go toward Sephar, the hill country of the east.

Conclusion

31 “These are the sons of Shem into their families, into their languages, in their lands, into their nations.

Genesis 10:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The line of Shem as a whole doesn’t lead to Abram. An important division takes place in Genesis 10:25.

Genesis 10:25 Instructor’s Translation

Now, to Eber, two sons were born,
the name of the one was Peleg (פלג),
for in his days the earth was divided (נפלג);
and his brother’s name was Joktan.

The genealogy of Shem splits off in two directions, creating a division between the brothers, just as in the previous narratives when the land was divided. This follows the same scheme that we saw earlier in the parallel design of Genesis 1-6 and 6-11.

Adam & Eve’s Line	Ham’s Line	Shem’s Line
Adam and Eve	1st generation: Noah	1st generation: Shem
Split between Cain and Abel/Seth	Split between Shem, Ham, Japheth	Split between Peleg and Joktan
Cain’s line leads to cosmic rebellion and the flood	Ham’s line leads to cosmic rebellion and the scattering	Shem’s line splits during a cosmic rebellion and division

Family Line Parallel Design . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

"It is significant that another genealogy of Shem is repeated after the account of the building of Babylon (11:1-9), and there the line is continued to Abraham through the first son of Eber, Peleg (11:10-26). In arranging the genealogy of Shem in this way, the author draws a dividing line through the descendants of Shem on either side of the city of Babylon. The dividing line falls between the two sons of Eber, that is, Peleg and Joktan. One line leads to the building of Babylon and the other to the family of Abraham. The author supplies a hint to this division of the line of Shem with the comment that in Peleg's day "the land was divided" (10:25). As throughout the biblical text, the "land" is often a reference to the "inhabitants of the land." Thus, not only is the land divided in the confusion of languages (11:1), but more fundamentally, two great lines of humanity diverge from the midst of the sons of Shem. Those who seek to make a name (11:4) for themselves in the building of Babylon and those for whom God will make a name (12:2) in the call of Abraham."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic.

Reflection Question

Does the curse on Canaan mean all Canaanites are bound to a certain fate?